



gathering wild food, and the small-scale farming of subfertile plots. Today the future of the Yanomami is uncertain. Since gold was discovered on their territory during the 1970s, they have endured violence, greed, and

infectious diseases at the hands of big business interests intent on exploiting the land. Both multinationals and poor migrants have also caused serious damage to the environment in their desperate search for gold.

RITUAL FOR THE DEAD

The Yanomami include fierce displays in many of their rituals. During funeral ceremonies, for example, warriors perform fantastic dances. Later, the deceased's body is burned and the ashes, along with ground-up bones, are mixed with soup and drunk by friends and family. In this way, they believe, the dead person becomes part of the living.



Ritual warriors cover their heads with white down.

LIVING OFF THE LAND

There isn't much room for farming in the rain forest, but clearing small plots allows the people to grow basic crops. Since most communities move on every few seasons to get the best from the soil, this task is repeated regularly. The working party shown here includes a youngster observing the process; knowledge has to be passed on in practical ways, as the Yanomami have no written language.

DECORATIVE PIERCING

Like some people in Western cultures, the Yanomami use piercing as a form of adornment. According to custom, thin wooden sticks are used; males perforate their bottom lip in the middle only, while females add an extra stick on each side.

